Scholar's Mate: the four-move trap

White's four moves, and how often they worked against each RankUp Chess bot.

WHITE'S FOUR MOVES

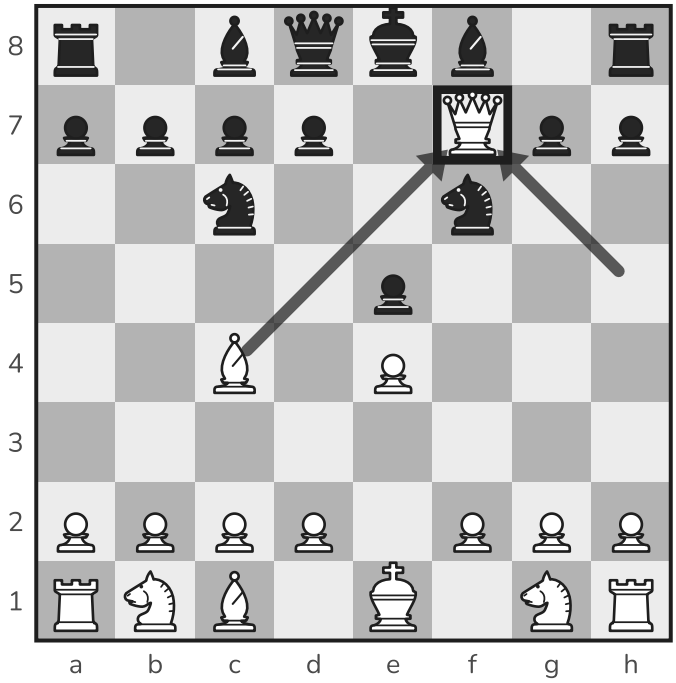
1 e4 Pawn to e4

2 Bc4 Bishop to c4

3 Qh5 Queen to h5

4 Qxf7# Queen takes f7: checkmate

The bishop and queen both aim at f7, the one square only the king guards at the start.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 Nf6?? 4.Qxf7#: checkmate.

What we found

The same four moves every game: 200 games against each bot.

Bot	Mated, of 200	
Baby Bean Starter bot	**70**	
Sleepy Sloth Starter bot	**20**	
Pip the Pawn Level 1	**6**	
Shelly the Crab Level 2	**6**	
Barnaby Beaver Level 3	**0**	
Origami Ollie Level 4	**2**	
Sir Reginald Level 5	**0**	
Rexa the Dino Level 6	**0**	
Captain Nova Level 7	**0**	
Queen Marina Level 8	**0**	uses no chance
Professor Bones Level 9	**0**	uses no chance
The Grand Admiral Level 10	**0**	uses no chance

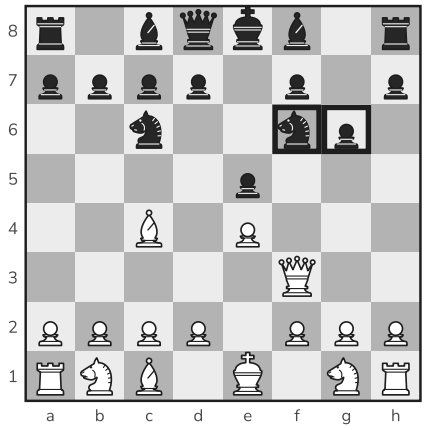
At levels 1 to 7, the bot took the queen on h5 in 336 of 1,400 games.

Levels 8 to 10 use no chance. Levels 8 and 9 answered the same way in all 200 games. Level 10 thinks for a set time, so its answer varied: it took the queen in 152. On a slower phone, all three might answer differently.

How we tested: White played 1.e4, 2.Bc4, 3.Qh5, then 4.Qxf7 only when it was mate, in every game. 200 games against each of the nine bots that use chance (1,800 in all) and 200 against each of levels 8 to 10, which use none, on the app's own bot code with a fresh engine each game, 7 November 2026.

How to stop it (playing Black)

Say you have Black, and White tries the trap. Three ways to stop it.

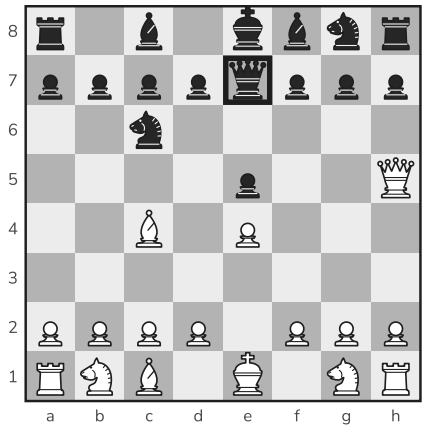


1 Pawn to g6

After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5, push the g-pawn: it blocks her and attacks her, and your knight on c6 guards e5. If she goes to f3, put a knight on f6.

After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 g6 4.Qf3 Nf6.

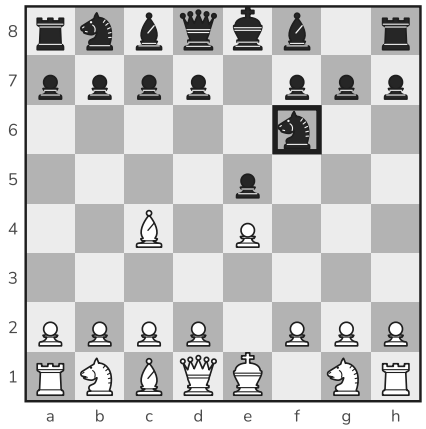
> Only with the knight on c6. Without it (say 2...Bc5 3.Qh5), ...g6 loses to Qxe5+, which hits the king and the rook on h8.



2 Queen to e7

Or guard f7 with your queen.

After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 Qe7.



3 Knight to f6, early

Before the queen comes out, a knight on f6 guards h5. Then Qh5 just loses the queen.

After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6.

The move to avoid

With the queen already on h5, don't play knight to f6. Queen takes f7 is checkmate.

ONE QUESTION FOR EVERY GAME

When a queen comes out early, ask: what is she aiming at?

Every position here is checked in python-chess, and each defence on the app's own engine.